

Jamshed J. Bhabha, that our goal should be to have as many Indians as possible in it," says Suntook. "Though we might still not have a fully Indian orchestra, a significant achievement is that we have several Indian players of international standard." He believes the orchestra's artistic growth has been equally significant. "The orchestra is now able to play advanced masterpieces such as Richard Strauss's tone poems and Mahler symphonies, accompany famous soloists and perform operas staged by the NCPA."

The anniversary season continues the SOI's Beethoven symphony cycle, culminating in 2027 to mark the composer's 200th death anniversary. "The idea came from our chief conductor Martyn Brabbins," Suntook explains. "Whenever there is a Beethoven work on offer, the house is almost sold out."

> SOI's anniversary season continues with **its Beethoven symphony cycle,** to mark 200 years of the composer's death in 2027

"We try and balance the great classics with less familiar repertoire," Suntook says, adding that as audiences develop, the orchestra plans to introduce more advanced works. As the SOI enters its third decade, Suntook believes it stands as proof that "a homegrown orchestra of international standard" can flourish in India. ■

—Nikhil Sardana

SOI's Autumn 2026 season runs at NCPA, Mumbai, from Aug. 16-30

THE MOST INTERESTING ADDITIONS THIS YEAR ARE 'AI—MACHINE MADE MOVIES' AND 'DANCING LENS'

celebrates "films where movement becomes the narrative. Dance can communicate emotion, identity and culture in ways that words often can't."

"Independent cinema gives people the freedom to tell deeply personal stories without worrying about commercial expectations," he says, adding, "Everyone has a story to tell. However, not everyone gets the opportunity to do so, and that's where festivals like BISFF become important." ■

—Deepa Natarajan Lobo

BISFF 2026 will be held online from Aug. 6-16, followed by its on-ground edition from Aug. 14-16

CINEMA ▼

Bend It Like a Caddie

Filmmaker Kabir Singh Chowdhry's documentary, *Scrap and Soul*, turns the gaze on the overlooked caddies of elite golf

Enter a perfectly manicured golf course, and chances are you will see through the caddies. But Chandigarh-based filmmaker Kabir Singh Chowdhry did the opposite. Admitting he came to the sport from a place of privilege, he stresses, "It was the time spent alongside the caddies that really shaped me as a player."

That old account has now been settled with *Scrap and Soul: The Rough Cut Classic*, his documentary about the men who know golf courses better than anyone who has ever paid to play on them. Chowdhry didn't train as a filmmaker, but his debut, *Mehsampur*, took the Grand Jury Prize in the India Gold competition at MAMI 2018, and later won Best Sound Design and Best Editing at MISAAF and the Diorama International Film Festival. The shoot in Chandigarh, he says, barely felt like direction. "The camera wasn't always in my hands." It was built on years of trust, a shared sense of humour—a film made with people, not on them, thanks to the seed money provided by social scientist Dr Pramod Kumar of the Institute for Development and Communication (IDC). Chowdhry is already moving—deep in prep on his next film, written by Akshay Singh. ■

—Sukant Deepak





LIFE'S HANDICAP
Top, Kabir Singh Chowdhry; below, a poster for *Scrap and Soul*